

THE WEIGHT OF QUIET

Written by

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Working title. One continuous shot, no cuts.
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FADE IN:

EXT. LAKE DISTRICT COTTAGE / FELLS - DUSK

Black. Then the grey ridge of mountains against darker sky.

The camera hangs high above a stone cottage. A single downstairs window burns gold.

It begins to descend. Not a fall. A glide. It snakes down through the cold, tilting toward the light the way a thing comes home.

Closer. The window. The sill. It slips through the gap where the pane sits open.

INT. COTTAGE - LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Into the room. Not peaceful. The quiet of a fight catching its breath.

Two mugs on the side table. One steams. The other, further off, is stone cold with a skin on it.

MAYA, 30s, coat still on, standing, arms folded. JAMES, 30s, in the little kitchen, drying a mug, at home in it.

The camera settles a few feet off his shoulder. He doesn't look at it. Something in him eases. A body that has decided it isn't alone. It is the wrong moment for it.

MAYA

Three hours. I drove us three hours
so we could stand in a different
kitchen and not talk.

JAMES

I'm talking.

MAYA

You're doing the washing up.

JAMES

It's one mug.

MAYA

You've dried it the whole time I've
been speaking.

He sets it down. Picks up another.

JAMES

There was a heron on the tarn this morning. Same spot as--

MAYA
I don't want to hear about the heron.

JAMES
It just stood there. Didn't move for--

MAYA
I do not care about the bird, James.

He puts the mug down. Doesn't come out of the kitchen. The counter between them like it's load-bearing.

MAYA (CONT'D)
Sit with me. Five minutes. Can you manage five minutes without finding something to wipe.

He comes through. Sits. The armchair, not the sofa. She clocks the distance. Says nothing about it, this time.

He settles. And then, quiet, barely there, to the empty end of the sofa nearest him, almost a smile:

JAMES
(barely)
Shove up.

She goes very still.

MAYA
What did you just say.

JAMES
Nothing.

MAYA
You said shove up.

JAMES
It's a figure of--

MAYA
Don't. Don't tell me it's a figure of speech. I know what it is. I know exactly what it is.

He rubs his face. Half a second where even he isn't sure. Gone again.

MAYA (CONT'D)

You made two coffees this morning.

JAMES

Oh, we're doing the coffees.

MAYA

Two. And the second one sweet. Two sugars. You don't take sugar, you haven't taken sugar in fifteen years, and you stood at that counter and stirred two sugars into a cup for--

JAMES

It's a cup of coffee.

MAYA

IT IS NOT A CUP OF COFFEE.

It rings off the stone walls. And she hears herself. On the surface it is, exactly, a cup of coffee. That is the thing she can never hold.

MAYA (CONT'D)

Do you have any idea what it's like. Trying to compete with someone who isn't even here. I can't win. There's no winning it. She doesn't leave wet towels, she doesn't get old, she never lets you down. She just gets to be gone. And perfect. And I'm the one who's still here.

JAMES

Don't.

MAYA

At least if she were alive I could hate her properly.

It is out before she can stop it. It is too far. She knows the second it lands.

JAMES

(quiet, and cold)
Say that again.

MAYA

I didn't--

JAMES

Go on. Say it again.

MAYA
I didn't mean it. James. I didn't
mean it.

JAMES
You meant it. You keep a little
list, don't you. The sugars. The
coffees. Who I look at. You stand
in the corner of your own marriage
with a clipboard.

MAYA
Because you LEFT.

JAMES
I'm sat right here.

MAYA
You went everywhere but here.
You've been gone in every room in
every house we've ever--

She stops herself. Starts again, uglier, because she's
frightened.

MAYA (CONT'D)
I am not the villain. Don't you
make me the villain in this. I have
been so patient I don't recognise
myself.

She crosses the room. Takes his face in both hands. Hard.

MAYA (CONT'D)
Look at me. Am I here. Am I still
in the room or have I gone too.

He looks. And for one second he is completely there, and she
hates how much she needs that second.

Then his eyes slide. Past her. To nothing. She feels his
face turn under her hands toward the empty air.

She lets go like it burned her.

MAYA (CONT'D)
There. There it is. I've got my
hands on your face and you still
went.

JAMES
(worn through)
I know. You've told me. You tell me
every time.

MAYA
Then fix it. Just fix it.

JAMES
I don't know how. You think I want
this? You think I chose any of--

MAYA
Put it down. Put it down for one
night and be my husband.

JAMES
It isn't--

MAYA
Don't. Don't say it isn't that
simple. You could. You choose it.
Every single day you choose it over
me and you call it something
happening to you.

JAMES
(up, loud)
It IS happening to me.

MAYA
Then let me in! Let me into the
room, once, just--

JAMES
There's no room--

MAYA
There is always a room. There is
always a room in you and I have
never once had a key.

He has nothing left. So he does the other thing. He crosses
to her and takes her, and it isn't tender, it's a collision,
a way to make the words stop. She shoves him in the chest,
then grabs a fistful of his shirt and hauls him back in.
Teeth. Two people who know each other's bodies and nothing
else that's any use tonight.

For a second it might be enough.

Then she feels it. His breath at her ear, his face turned
away. She opens her eyes.

He is looking past her. Over her shoulder. At the room.
Holding her, and gone.

She shoves him off, hard.

MAYA

You're... even now. Even now,
James. I have got my hands on you
and you are still--

She can't finish it. She's shaking.

He is already half-turned back toward the space.

JAMES
(to it, lost)
I don't even know if you're--

He can't finish either. He doesn't know who he's asking. He doesn't know if anyone's there.

He drifts to the window and opens it again, without knowing he's done it. The cold comes back in.

MAYA
You've opened it again. James. Look
at what you're doing.

He doesn't hear her. His hand comes up. Reaching toward the empty air beside him. Palm open. At a height. For a shoulder that should be there.

His fingers an inch from the lens.

And he sees it. His own hand. The two mugs. The cold sweet coffee. The open window. Maya. Himself. The empty end of the sofa. The whole shape of it, all at once.

His face comes apart.

JAMES
(barely)
No.

His arm sweeps the side table. The cold mug hits the floor and breaks.

MAYA
(small now, frightened)
James.

He isn't looking at her. He's looking at the air. He backs away from it, and it comes after him, gentle, closer, not understanding.

JAMES
(pleading, to no one she
can see)
Not now. Not tonight. Go on.
Please. Go.

MAYA
(barely a whisper)
Who are you talking to.

And there it is. The full size of it, finally, in her face.

JAMES
(a roar, torn out of him,
at nothing at all)
FUCK OFF!

The camera flinches.

Then it BOLTS. Back, hard, away from him, across the room,
over the broken mug, out through the open window.

EXT. COTTAGE / FELS - CONTINUOUS

Out into the cold and UP. Fast. Climbing. The gold window
shrinking below.

The mountains. The dark. All that empty country.

It stops, high over the roof. Looks down.

At the small lit cottage. At the one warm window. At the man
inside it, tiny now, both hands over his face.

And Maya behind him. Not going to him. Watching the man she
loves shake at an empty room, a broken cup at his feet, and
nothing there. Nothing at all.

The camera holds in the dark. Tilted down. The way you look
at a place you have just been put out of.

The way an intruder looks at a house.

FADE OUT.